



attack. The reverse sweep and the switch hit may be his calling cards, but he left them in the kitbag that evening, proving he could win through patience as much as power.

He knows adaptability is key. "I have to be ready to accept any challenge, whether it's batting from No. 3 to No. 7. I'm really working on mental toughness as much as skills. My target is to guide the team home, even when the asking rate is 12 an over. Never easy, but I'm learning to adapt."

That adaptability reflects in his T20I record — a study in range and role-awareness. At No. 3, Tilak has

piled up 443 runs at an average of 55.37 and a strike rate of 169.73, elite numbers that underline his authority as a top-order enforcer. **Drop him to No. 4, and he remains just as productive: 435 runs at 62.14 with a strike rate of 134.67, thriving amid middle-overs traffic where others often stall.** Even when slotted lower down — a 31 not out at No. 5, a 29 at No. 7 — he has found ways to make an impact. Across positions, his 10 fifty-plus scores and 50-plus career average reveal a batter capable of anchoring, accelerating, or rescuing, depending on what the game demands.

And fittingly, he batted at No. 4 in the Asia Cup final against Pakistan — a night that tested every ounce of that adaptability. India beat Pakistan by five wickets in a tense finish to retain the title at the Dubai International Cricket Stadium. Chasing 147, India lost three wickets in the opening three overs to give Pakistan hope. But Tilak's unbeaten 53-ball 69 calmed things down, eventually taking the Men in Blue past the finish line. Reflecting on that Asia Cup final, Tilak was quick to point out that he'd done similar things before. "But since that knock came under such pressure, with